

SECURING THE Home Front

Wanted: A single, unified internal security set up to guard India against major terror strikes



Union Minister of Home Affairs P. Chidambaram is acutely aware that he has very little time to deliver with the general elections due in May 2009. In a way it is fortuitous because what India needs after the Mumbai attacks is action, and fast. In the saddle for just over a month, Chidambaram at a meeting of chief ministers on internal security on January 6 said his immediate priority was to raise the level of preparedness to meet the increasingly sophisticated terrorist threats. Equally important was to enhance the speed and decisiveness of the response to a terrorist threat or attack.

Both these measures are key to inspiring confidence of the country that has been severely punctured after the Mumbai attacks. But even as Chidambaram gets cracking on the stiff agenda he has set for himself and the Government, he needs to examine the functioning of his Ministry more closely.

The Union Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) has to play a pivotal role if the war on terror has to be won. But in the

past few years, the Ministry exemplifies what has gone wrong with the country's management of internal security. In the six months, preceding the Mumbai attacks, there were blasts in Delhi, Jaipur, Bangalore, Ahmedabad and Guwahati that killed 215 and injured 1,000. Typically after these attacks, there were "security review" meetings which saw the buck being passed from one authority to another and no responsibility being fixed. Routine alerts were sent to states to tighten their security with no follow up.

After Mumbai, it was evident that the MHA had to radically change its approach. It has its hands in just too many issues. Apart from internal security and terrorism, its mandate is to tackle insurgency in Jammu and Kashmir (J&K) and the Northeastern states, Left wing extremism, border management, immigration, foreign funding, Centre-state relations, Union Territories, managing the Indian Police Service (IPS) and Central paramilitary forces, police modernisation and policy planning. Experts say, over the years the ministry has grown into a behemoth that



PRIME MINISTER
MANMOHAN SINGH
WITH CHIDAMBARAM

is difficult to manage, has dragged its feet on key proposals like police modernisation, did nothing to sort out turf battles between intelligence agencies both at the level of the Centre and the states and has failed to come up with an effective anti-terror policy.

After 9/11, the George Bush administration decided that what it needed was a humongous Homeland Security Department that would, in the American President's view, "make America safer because our nation would have one department whose primary mission is to protect the American homeland." Bush decided that there would be only one department to secure US borders, transport sector, ports and critical infrastructure, apart from synthesising and analysing homeland security intelligence from multiple sources, training

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